

"I am very proud of all that you've achieved, Vilde," Arianwen replies. "I really am. But don't ask me to stand by and watch you die. I won't do it."

"You just don't think I can do it," Vilde says quietly. "You don't trust me."

A flash of anger burns across the Senator's face as she realizes Vilde refuses to see her way. "By the way, we've left *Dawn and Dusk* at home," Arianwen says. "You didn't think we'd be stupid enough to bring it here for you to steal and run away, did you?"

WISDOM (INSIGHT) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Vilde sees that a guilty look pass over Angwyn's face.

"Are you serious?" Vilde asks. "Daddy? What do you think about all this?"

"Listen to your mother, Vilde," Angwyn says, continuing to rub her mother's back.

"Go," Arianwen says. "Say goodbye to your friends. Tonight's the last time you're going to see them."

Vilde storms out of the room as the Senator collapses into tears, sobbing.

LETTERS FROM THE FRONT

Raphael, Wang Lei and Salazar, still in Breakbones's office, takes some time to pen their replies.

Salazar replies McGonagall, thanking her for her recommendation and assuring her that he is doing his best to save her. He then presses her for more information about the book she had given him - *Shadow of the Whispered One: The Formative Years of the Architect* - and asks how is his memory loss related to the liches. He also shares about Wang Lei's Gray Baby patron, explaining that "there is something amiss" and ask if she "knows anything about the gray baby in Raya."

Salazar also replies the Ring of Gold, detailing the heroic efforts of the 22nd Expedition who ultimately fell to the False Hydra. The wizard, seeking a second opinion, also asks the Ring about liches, necromancy and memory loss. He also shares about the Gray Baby, seeking more knowledge about it.

Raphael sends a letter to the Lord Atakan, informing the patriarch of House Tokugane that he has received his letter. He shares that his father is dead, and asks about the "current status of the *Court of Owls* project." The sorcerer indicates his interest in taking up Atakan's offer regarding the project. Raphael also takes the opportunity to check in on Hinari.

Raphael also takes the opportunity to reply to the Lady Isolde Antarra, remarking that the events happening in the Victorian Empire, as well as Antarra's new alliance with Tychonis is incredibly shocking. He shares that while members of the 51st were captured, Kaelen is still free, leading a group of rogue Guardsmen in a hunt for a dragon. He commits to apprehending Kaelen as soon as possible so as to make him face justice.

The sorcerer also tells the Lady Antarra that he is unhappy with the betrothal, and that he does not "currently have the mental capacity to deal with this right now." Citing that the mission is at hand, Raphael tells his grandmother that he is "not looking and does not wish to be distracted by matters that does not pertain to the mission." Raphael also emphasises that she need not send his cousins, and that "he alone is enough."

Wang Lei drafts a quick letter to Castellan Eddard Raimond, checking in on how he is doing. He quickly details the vision he saw back at the Thundering Lizard where the Castellan had a fight with the new Lieutenant, and asks his foster father to write back as soon as possible and update on his well-being.

The trio sends off the letters, and also helps Hazel and Vilde mail theirs: Hazel sends a simple, wet letter with nothing written signed with a muddy paw print as well as two, loose platinum pieces to her family; Vilde pieces together a threatening "I AM COMING FOR YOU. P.S. I know your daughter is a baddie, I'm coming for her also. P.P.S. FOR A DIFFERENT REASON" in a dizzying number of conflicting fonts and letter styles sourced from tearing out a bunch of newspapers to the Lord Atakan, unbeknownst to Raphael.

RETAIL THERAPY

Gathering back out in the bazaar, the Party does some quick shopping. Frustrated by the conversation with her mother, Vilde indulges in some retail therapy. Coming up with Hazel and Wukong, Vilde spots Hazel buying a load of magical items, including the *Eyes of Deceit*.



"Wait a minute, where did you get all this money from?" The rogue asks.

"It's my inheritance," Hazel lies. "My parents were forced out of their home, and it went en bloc so they made a bunch of gold and mailed it over with the letters."

"I was there receiving all the letters though," Vilde points out. The rogue narrows her eyes at the harregon paying, still suspicious.

The gnome merchant appears, introducing his wares to the Party. Salazar points out that they have a big purchase, and asks if they can enjoy a discount of some kind. Vilde joins in, sweet-talking the kind gnome.

CHARISMA (PERSUASION) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Vilde wins a 13% discount and two *Bags of Holding*.

Wang Lei, while perusing his wares, spots two beautiful, long black cloaks made from raven plumage. Recognizing its ability to grant flight and increased senses, he tells Vilde that he intends to buy it and that it might be a good gift for Mason. He sets the gems he has, acquired by the Gray Baby, on the table as payment, along with the rest of his equipment.



Vilde sees Salazar sneakily put a *Cloak of Protection* into the pile of goods they are buying, and asks how is he intending to pay for that. Salazar tries bartering, eventually acquiescing to owe her five "no-questions-asked" favors.

As the Party complete their purchases, Melian - a servant in Vilde's house - approaches the Party, kneeling and kowtowing to Vilde. The rogue asks her to

rise, prompting Melian to inform the Party that the Senator Arianwen Amadeus has invited the entire Party to dinner tonight. She explains that the Senator wishes to get to know her new Expedition, and is thus holding the dinner.

"Her new Expedition?" Vilde asks. "Don't you mean *my* Expedition?"

Melian shrugs. "I'm just a messenger."

"Do you know where's my Daddy?" Vilde demands.

WISDOM (INSIGHT) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Vilde sees that Melian is not at all interested in or serving the interests of her father Angwyn. On a successful DC 20 check, Vilde sees that Melian is only interested in serving Arianwen and Vilde, in that particular order.

"I'm not entirely sure where he went," Melian responds. "He was in the Senator's office just now, but I don't know where he headed off to."

"Okay, sure," Vilde replies. "With regards to the dinner, we might be there."

"Are you intending to sneak away?" Melian asks.

"Please don't ask so many questions," Vilde fired back. "Remember your place."

Melian immediately kneels on the floor, bowing so deeply once again her forehead touches the ground. "I'm sorry, my lady."

"Leave us, please," Vilde demands. As Melian gets out of earshot, the rogue turns back and updates the rest of the Party on her conversation with the Senator Arianwen.

Hazel, who was momentarily flabbergasted at this revelation, remembers that Vilde has shared all of this before. Reminded that the whole reason they came to Camp Vengeance was to help Vilde get her weapons, she asks "where are the scimitars?"

Vilde shares her growing suspicion that Angwyn had brought along the scimitars - *Dawn* and *Dusk* - against her mother's wishes. She suggests that the Party steals it.

"Why doesn't your mum want to give you the scimitars?" Raphael says suddenly, having returned from his trip to look for a mask to cover up his face.

"Where did you come from?" Vilde asks, shocked. "But, anyway, I think she wants me to be safe, and head back to govern Nike."

The Party strategises: Vilde, Salazar and Raphael want to talk to the 51st Expedition, while Wang Lei says he

has to check out Gaya's armoury. As they debate on the order to approach the items, Hazel realizes Thaisha is not with them. Trusting that she is doing something important, she shrugs it off.

THE LAST STANDARD

Hazel and Wang Lei heads off to the armoury to find Gaya.

Entering the armoury, you see that what used to be a dusty sealed off store with stacks of shortswords and shields piled unceremoniously have been expanded to a full smithy. In the corner, making the hot jungle even hotter, is a stone forge. You see several Guardsmen working in the workshop as rhythmic clangs of a hammer against an anvil echoes off. Racks of gleaming steel swords, heavy chainmail jackets, and crates of raw, reddish iron ore line the walls.

"Hiya boss," the Knight Gaya Seremai stands up, having previously been lounging with his boots up on his desk. "Got a couple of shields I think you'd like."

"You look like you're doing very well for yourself," Wang Lei points out.

"Well, yes," Gaya replies. "All thanks to you."

Following into a small back room, laid out on a table are two shields. The first one does not look like a shield at all, and instead looks like two separate bracers.

"This is the *Shield of the Everfighter*," Gaya explains. "I know you love using halberds, and this is fantastic for a halberd user. It allows you to enjoy the benefits of a shield while using a two-handed halberd."

"And this, well, I'm not sure if you'd like this," Gaya continues presenting. "This is the *Maw of the Abyss*. The face of the second shield is seemingly made of teeth, with a clear, fanglike line through its centre. "It can split open upon command and bite down on a target. Maybe even consume it. Which one are you thinking of?"

"I can only get one?" Wang Lei asks.

"Oh," Gaya replies. "You want both?"

"I'm just asking," Wang Lei smiles.

"It's just some of the boys were hoping to get an equipment upgrade, that's all," Gaya explains. "If you'd like both, a small donation would be nice."

Wang Lei and Hazel discusses it, eventually deciding on grabbing both shields. They donate 200 gold pieces to

Gaya's smithy.

"That's not all. I've also got a couple of leads on some of the other items you asked me to look into," the knight continues. "No leads on the *Plate*, but there's a legendary halberd - *The Last Standard*. Rumour has it was Mezro's last battle standard which they took into battle, which was ultimately destroyed by Raya during the War of Axe and Vine. The Rayans took it back as a trophy and framed it in a museum."

Gaya calls out for Goldenguard, intending to toss the gold to the dwarf and get him to update the inventory. His calls fall on deaf ears as no one enters the backroom. Confused, the knight just takes the gold and tells Hazel and Wang Lei that "he'll sort out the paperwork."

"Alright," Wang Lei continues. "If there's nothing else, just keep on looking into the Plate for me."

"Oh, about that," Gaya continues. "I've been given new orders, boss. Captain wants me to lead a detachment down south to find Pearne. I'm delegating most of the work to Goldenguard - he's my shield guy - but I can't seem to find him in the moment."

"Alright, no problem," Wang Lei replies. "Good luck out there."

POWER AND STRENGTH

While Wukong, Salazar, Vilde and Raphael continue shopping, the sorcerer spots a pair of knights jousting in the field just outside the bazaar. Raphael is drawn to them, wandering away from the bustling crowd towards the field.

Raphael, you unwittingly walk closer and closer into the jousting field. Before long you find yourself near the riders.

You see that the two knights ride at full speed into each other, as one slams their lances into the chest of the other, unseating him. As the knight is knocked off his horse, the horse continues its gallop straight at you, unable to stop its momentum.

At the last second, the horse rears up at you, stopping abruptly. Before you can even process what's happening, you cast *Arms of Hadar*.

Tentacles explode out from your chest as it grapples the horse, lifting it up in mid-air. They tighten along the limbs of the horse and pull violently, ripping the poor beast completely apart. As it does to, its head falls, which you catch it with ease. Your fingers dig into the horse's head, slick with blood, and digs out its eyeballs. You pop them in your mouth.



“Bessie! Bessie!” Screams break out all across the jousting field, drawing everybody’s attention. Vilde, Wukong and Salazar rush to the field.

DEXTERITY (STEALTH) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, everybody sees that the horse has been reduced into nothing but entrails but nobody sees the culprit.

As they round up, Salazar intuits that this is a sign of magical madness, which could possibly be contracted by attuning to dangerous artifacts. The wizard asks Vilde if she has seen Raphael attune to anything dangerous recently.

“What do you mean?!” Vilde asks, exasperated. “It’s the creepy book, we all saw him attune to it.” Disgusted, Vilde asks gently, “Um, Raphael? Do you know what you just did?”

Raphael, having come to, puts two and two together. “Uh, yeah,” He says. “I think it’s a side effect from attuning to the *Nekronomicon*,” the sorcerer explains. “It’s alright, it’ll pass.”

“Are you sure you want to remain attuned to the book?” Salazar asks. “I mean... eating eyeballs doesn’t sound natural. Or good.”

“Maybe you shouldn’t come to the dinner,” Vilde points out. “Um... I don’t think it’s safe.”

INTELLIGENCE (ARCANA) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Salazar and Raphael both realize that a *Lesser Restoration* spell would likely do the trick to dispel the madness.

Vilde, Salazar, Wukong and Raphael leaves the jousting field quickly, intending to buy some eyes from the bazaar.

Leaving the armoury, Wang Lei and Hazel hear screams from the jousting field.

WISDOM (PERCEPTION) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Wang Lei sees Goldenguard strolls out of the Camp.

Leaving the smithy, completely ignoring the chaos, you see a small dwarven paladin in ring mail look around shiftily as he heads out.

Wang Lei taps Hazel, nudging his head at the suspicious dwarf. Both of them decide to sneak after the dwarf quietly. Hiding behind some crates, the pair spots a small harregon with red robes come up quietly.

Hazel, you recognise that it is Fiverr.

“Kid,” Goldenguard says. “Have you gotten the gold?”

Fiverr produces a small bag of gold, as the dwarf retrieves a small blue pouch.

“Nice doing business with ya,” Goldenguard says. The dwarf strolls off, intending to do a loop around the Camp’s perimeter. Fiverr turns and heads back into the Camp.

Hazel ambushes out, slapping the back of Fiverr’s head.

“Ow,” Fiverr complains. “What the heck?”

“Wa, what were you doing out here?” Hazel asks, trying to smack Fiverr again. This time, the harregon rogue is ready. He dodges his sister’s strike.

“Stop that!” He protests.

“Fess up,” Hazel threatens. “He’s the owner of the Camp, you know.” The cleric points at Wang Lei, who is just standing there with his arms on his hips.

CHARISMA (INTIMIDATION) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, the pair scares Fiverr into showing the pouch.

“He’s not going to turn me in or anything right?” Fiverr asks.

“Well, it depends,” Hazel shrugs. “But I’ll help you.”

Undoing the pouch, Fiverr shows Hazel and Wang Lei. They spot a white powder they are intimately familiar

with.

"Wa, kublacaine?!" Hazel asks. Instinctively the cleric reaches out to smack the rogue again, who leans back to dodge it.

"I need it, okay!" Fiverr explains. "It's a big boy's world here, and we need all the help we can get -"

WISDOM (INSIGHT) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Hazel sees that Fiverr has never consumed the drug before. Beating a DC 20 check, Hazel intuits that Fiverr wants the drug for its ability to boost physical capabilities.

In a fit of rage, Hazel *Produces Flame*. Hurling the fire, the spell strikes true and incinerates the drugs. "Trust me, I'm saving you."

Wang Lei nods as he backs up Hazel. "From my experience, it's not worth it. You would not want to deal with the addiction."

"Yeah, give him the drug talk," Hazel encourages.

"Woah why the heck did you do that?" Fiverr protests. "It was super expensive, you know."

"And why did you want it?" Wang Lei asks.

"Have you guys ever had it before?" Fiverr continues. "It gives you super strength and super speed. I need it to survive out there."

"Yeah, accidentally," Wang Lei replies. "But you know, it has severe drawdowns too."

"Just stay in camp," Hazel says. "Your sister will do everything for you."

"I don't want that!" Fiverr storms off in a tantrum. As he does so, Hazel casts *Thorn Whip*. A stalk of plant grows out of the ground, catching the rogue by his foot and pulling him back.

"Stop that!" Fiverr pulls out a dagger and starts cutting himself free.

"Can't you just throw him in jail?" Hazel asks. "Like... the cushiest jail around."

"I'll speak with Breakbones," Wang Lei shrugs. "But anyway, Fiverr, you don't need drugs to be strong. Look at your sister. You just need some magic items." The paladin points to the cleric's *Belt of Hill Giant Strength*.

Hazel furrows her eyebrows at her pesky brother, and eventually heals him with *Healing Word*. "Alright, I'll give you some stuff," Hazel rummages through her stuff. "Maybe I should give him the *Ring of Split Mind* -"

"Okay, don't be crazy," Wang Lei says. "He's not even a spellcaster."

"Okay fine," Hazel acquiesces. She produces the *Helm of the Ram* and the *Staff of Flowers*, tossing it to her brother. "There you go. Especially the staff - it's a secret item."

Fiverr flicks the staff, summoning a bunch of flowers from its end.

"You'd be surprised at how useful it is," Hazel says. "You better stay safe out there, or I'll throw you into jail."

"What?" Fiverr looks up at Wang Lei. "Can he do that?"

The paladin shrugs.

"Behave yourself!" Hazel calls after the Fiverr as he dips back into the Camp. The pair head off to warn Gaya that Goldenguard has been dealing drugs, prompting the knight to tell them that "he will have a word with him."

ON DEATH ROW

Reuniting in the bazaar, the Party catches the pair up on the horse incident and why Raphael is eating eyeballs. Hazel casts *Lesser Restoration* on the sorcerer. With his madness cured, Raphael vomits all of his food out. Seeing this, Salazar cannot hold in his disgust and regurgitates his lunch as well.

The Party decides to head off to the jail cells. On the way, Vilde shares that while she does not want Ariadne to be hanged on false charges, she also does not really want to recruit her. Raphael says "we can decide after talking to them."

Situated below the inner bailey, all of you make your way to the cells with no problem, having previously told Breakbones of your intention to speak to the 51st Expedition.

Entering into this dusty, musty, space, you see that this is a rudimentary place, not meant for spellcasters at all. Four jail cells stand before you, of which only three are occupied. Each of its occupants are flushed against the wall, forced to stand by manacles. Their fingers are all kept apart by a special metallic gauntlet of some kind, preventing any movement at all. The three occupants all have leather muzzles over their mouth.

Vilde, you recognize your half-sister Ariadne; Salazar, you recognize the red-headed elf as Taylor Swyft. In the last cell is a young human boy with messy, spiky hair.

Vilde suggests plugging all their ears with wax so that they cannot corroborate their stories. As the Party goes

about doing that, the Party discusses their order of attack. Salazar suggests recruiting Taylor, but is shot down by the rest of the Party. Confused at Gwynne's absence, knowing that four of them were apprehended, the Party searches around the cells.

INTELLIGENCE (INVESTIGATION) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Salazar find the duty room. He finds a set of reports remarking on the status of each prisoner, noting that one of them - an earth genasi woman - was sent to the infirmary.

Salazar shares with the Party, prompting the Party to split up. Hazel and Wukong head off to find Sister Cyas, while the rest head into Ariadne's cell to get more information.

As Vilde walks up and undo Ariadne's leather muzzle, the elf's eyes widen in recognition.

"Do you know who I am?" Vilde asks.

"Yes, oh my gods," Ariadne replies. "Mum told me all about you. You're Vilde, right?"

"Yeah, okay, slow down," Vilde says. "What did she say?"

"That we're half sisters!" Ariadne replies excitedly. "You're here to save me! This is fantastic! Let me out!"

"Yeah, we'll do that," Vilde says slowly. "First, you must tell us everything about Kaelen and the other members of the 51st Expedition."

"Oh, Kaelen..." Ariadne's voice trails off as she tries to recall. "I think he wanted to hunt down a dragon... Tzindelor! I called him Tinder. The dragon's lair was at Wyrnheart Mine, but Kaelen had some plan to lure the dragon to Hrakhammer to kill it. But Taylor, she wanted to do what they were sent here to do, which is to stop the Graying. T-they had a big fight and that's when we split up. We haven't seen them since."

"And how did you all end up here?"

"Couple of days ago, we ran into a Victorian Revolutionary Guard patrol," Ariadne continues. "They claimed that there was some bounty out on us and they arrested us. I- I don't know what the bounty is for, or what crime we've committed. Something about killing a Castellan?"

"Yeah, I think that Kaelen probably did something," Vilde explains. "And all of you got lumped in together."

"Do you know the people who run Camp Vengeance?" Ariadne asks. "Maybe you can talk to them, let them know it's all been a big misunderstanding so they'd free us."

"Yeah, okay," Vilde says. "No promises, but we'll try." The rogue looks at Wang Lei momentarily, before turning her attention back to her half sister. "Do you know anything about - who was it again - a Sergeant Pearne?"



"I've never heard of this... Pearne character," Ariadne explains. "We were on our way to Dungrunglung, a grung settlement somewhere in the Aldani Basin, when we had the fight and split up. Halleck, Boots, and Old Hew - the guide - went with Kaelen on to Dungrunglung to rendezvous with some soldiers while the rest of us journeyed on."

"Who's Halleck?" Vilde asks. "Have we met him before?"

"Uh, I think he was a vassal knight serving under Kaelen as his bodyguard," Ariadne explains. "But I think there's more to it... you see, they sleep together."

"Oh?" Vilde asks. "Kaelen's gay?"

"Who cares," Raphael points out. "Gay or not, he's going to die."

WISDOM (INSIGHT) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Vilde sees an extremely scared girl whose first adventure has landed her on death row. Beating a DC 20 check, Vilde realizes that Ariadne is telling the full truth. Ariadne implicitly trusts Vilde, and by extension her Party, because she is her half-sister.

Recognizing this, Vilde asks softly, "Don't you hate me? I mean, I stole your life."

"Why would I hate you?" Ariadne asks, incredulous. "I always wanted a sister."

"Don't you want to," Vilde asks. "I don't know, rule Nike?"

"No?" Ariadne says. "I mean, I - I want to learn spells, and get good in magic, and I want to help people understand the world around them -"

"Okay, so power or family?"

"Huh?" Ariadne asks.

"Choose one! Power or family!"

"Family?" Ariadne replies, confounded.

Looking around and reading the room, Vilde decides to recruit her half-sister. "Okay, do you want to join us on our Expedition?"

"Oh, of course! That sounds great!"

"Yeah, okay, just a warning," Vilde says. "Be careful of some of them. They can be a bit... pervy." Turning to the Party, Vilde demands, "No touching my sister!" The rogue keeps her eyes on Salazar before turning back to Ariadne. "And if anybody touches you, you tell me."

"Okay!" Ariadne replies chirpily.

"Don't worry, you'll learn a lot from me, young one," Salazar says, to skeptical looks all around. The Party files out of the cell as they discuss who to talk to next.

Entering the next cell, you see a young human boy with unkempt, messy hair. His fringe is so long it is obscuring his eyes, almost to the point where you cannot see them.

Like Ariadne, he is manacled to the wall and forced to stand, although the chains are much lower given his size.

Removing his muzzle, Raphael takes the lead. "What's your involvement with the 51st Expedition?"

"I was conscripted." The boy replies slowly, as if chewing every single word.

"By who?" Wang Lei asks.

"By the Empress."

"Where are you from?" Raphael asks.

"The mainland."

"Where in the mainland?" The sorcerer demands, impatient. "We're all from the mainland." Leaning in close, Raphael sees that Eren has completely vacant eyes - as if he does not care about anything in the world.



"The Jungle," the boy replies nonchalantly.

INTELLIGENCE (HISTORY) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Wang Lei does not recognize the boy. However, he recognizes the boy's attire as a druid and intuits that Eren may be involved in one of the druid circles in the Jungle.

"Do you have anything to drink?" Eren asks. Salazar steps forward to provide some water, but Raphael stops him.

"This isn't a resort," the sorcerer says. He turns back to Eren. "And what's your relationship with Kaelen?"

"He was our leader."

"Was?" Wang Lei asks. "And who is it now?"

"Taylor," Eren replies.

"And what do you want to achieve now?" Wang Lei asks.

"Go home," the boy says firmly.

"Well, none of us are going home until the Devourer is destroyed," the paladin points out.

As the Party discusses his motivations, Salazar remarks that "he is being difficult."

"What about me is being difficult?" The boy asks. "If you aren't getting the answers you want, maybe you should be a bit more specific with your questions."

"Okay, it's chill," Vilde says. "Maybe he's just like those super intelligent types."

"Then we shouldn't recruit him," Salazar says. "I'm supposed to be the intelligent one in the group." The boy smirks at the comment, but remains otherwise silent.

"And what are your next steps if we set you free?" Raphael asks.

"Depends," the boy shrugs. "On what Lady Taylor asks."

"You'll only do what Taylor wants you to do?" Vilde asks.

"She's been a pretty good leader so far," Eren says.

INTELLIGENCE (ARCANA) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Salazar recognizes that there is no magic of any kind swaying the druid's mind. Beating a DC 20 check, the wizard recognizes that Eren is probably mildly autistic and is happy to have someone tell him what to do.

"I'm pretty sure we're not enemies," Raphael says. "We'll be speaking to her next. Anything you want to let

her know?"

The boy shrugs. "She likes alcohol. Maybe get her a drink." The Party muzzles the boy again as they head out to prepare to talk to Taylor.

THE WOMAN IN THE IRON MASK

Walking into the infirmary, you see Sister Cyas bent over, working hard on a counter.

Wukong taps Sister Cyas, explaining that "she's here in place of Salazar for the medical thing."

WISDOM (PERCEPTION) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Hazel sees that the infirmary has been expanded and is much better furnished. She also notes that there were a lot more empty beds, courtesy of having less injured and sick soldiers. Beating a DC 20 check, Hazel sees an earth genasi woman in a strait jacket.

"What do you need me to do?" Hazel asks politely.

"Oh," Sister Cyas asks, crestfallen. "I thought Salazar would be coming."

"Oh, he didn't want to come," Hazel says. She sees that Sister Cyas is heartbroken that Salazar did not want to see her.

"Right, okay," Sister Cyas turns around, gesturing for them to follow. "Right this way. This is Gwynne Parker; she's part of the 51st Expedition, and was arrested by some of the soldiers on patrol. She's been kept here, away from the others, instead of down in the cells because she's been claiming that she has never met the rest of them and does not know any of them."

Hopping onto the bed, Hazel pokes the earth genasi woman. She has also a similar leather muzzle over her mouth, preventing spellcasting.

WISDOM (INSIGHT) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Hazel sees that this woman is incredibly terrified and has no idea why she is held prisoner.

"Okay, give me her vitals," Hazel declares.

WISDOM (MEDICINE) CHECK

On a successful DC 20 check, Hazel sees that there is nothing wrong with this woman - there is no sign of medical condition or magical amnesia causing the earth genasi to behave in this way.

"Alright," Hazel undoes the lady's leather muzzle. The woman is inconsolable, in tears, confused at where she is and does not know what has happened.

"Help, please," the woman begs. "I don't know why they got me locked up like this." She starts to struggle against her bonds.

"Okay, calm down," Hazel says gently. "Who is they? I'm here to help."

The woman's eyes drift towards Sister Cyas.

"Uh, are you sure this is a good idea?" Sister Cyas asks. "She might be a spellcaster -"

"Trust me," Hazel says. "I'm a professional." The cleric remembers her time back on Princess during the dinosaur race and matches this woman's build to Gwynne, but is suspicious still that this woman does not recall the events.

"What's your name? How did you get here?"

"My name is Portia," the earth genasi replies. "The last thing I remember is putting on a mask, and t-that's it."

"Where are her belongings?" Hazel asks.

"It should be at the cells, with all of the other prisoners' belongings," Sister Cyas replies.

Hazel, using her Sending stone, informs Vilde. She directs them to go find the mask, warning that it might be cursed.

Rummaging through the jail cells, Wang Lei, Raphael, Salazar and Vilde find an ornate iron mask with two white eyes. As he picks up the mask, Salazar is overwhelmed by a powerful urge to don the mask, but stops as Vilde and Raphael calls out.



"Uh, found it," Salazar smiles weakly. "I don't know. I felt a strong urge to wear it." Seeing Wang Lei come in, Salazar feigns to put it on the paladin, only for Wang Lei to smack the mask off his hand.

"Stop with that shit, please," Wang Lei says. As the four of them screw around with the mask, Vilde tells Hazel that "they have found the mask, and that it might be cursed with a spirit of some kind since it tried to take control of Salazar."

Upon hearing this, Hazel realizes that the mask must have been in control of Portia. "Okay, you can send her to the outpatient now."

"She's cured?" Sister Cyas asks, confused.

"Yes, she's cured," Hazel says. "Trust me."

"Are you sure? You didn't even, I don't know, cast any spells or anything."

"Yes, I'm sure," Hazel continues. "And that's Doctor Hazel to you."

CHARISMA (PERSUASION) CHECK

On a successful DC 20 check, Sister Cyas acquiesces and lets Hazel release the patient. She calls the guards to move Portia into the jail cells.

The pair then make their way back into the cells, only to find the four of them bickering in the duty room, trying to put the mask on one another. Putting their heads together, the Party studies the mask.

INTELLIGENCE (ARCANA) CHECK

On a successful DC 15 check, Salazar, Hazel and Raphael discern that the mask is a powerful artifact that will likely take control of a body that dons it. On a DC 20 check, they come to the conclusion that the mask is likely sentient, calling itself Gwynne in response.

Beating a DC 25 check, Salazar recognizes that this is probably an artifact related to the spider-goddess Lolth.

As the spellcasters discuss, Vilde finds the second half of the *Spider's Gauntlet* in Gwynne's belongings. The rogue pockets the device, donning it on for a full set.

As the Party debates on what they should do with the mask, Raphael presses on. He heads towards Taylor's cell, pulling everybody along.

Letting Salazar take the lead, all of you walk to Taylor's cell. You all watch the wizard practically hop over, eager to speak to his idol. Watching this, Raphael whispers to the Party, "Okay, this man only has three outs. If he wastes it being

weird, we take over.”

“I think he should only have one,” Wang Lei shrugs as they cross the threshold.

“Oh my gods!” Salazar exclaims. “Ah! You’re Taylor Swyft! I’m your biggest fan.” Muttering under his breath to himself, the wizard continues, “Calm down Salazar, you can do it.”

Taylor raises an eyebrow at this display. “May I have some water, please?”

“Questions first, my lady,” Salazar remarks. “You’ll get water coming your way. What’s your role on this Expedition? Why do I hear that you are some leader? I mean - I know that you are the goddess of music, but - “

Vilde explodes into laughter as Hazel chimes in, “Oh, you’re Taylor! I know your songs, *Golden*, right?”

“No, please,” Salazar chides. “She sang *The Fate of Ophidia* - “

“I don’t know what the hells is that - “ Hazel interrupts.

“I mean, I have sung a cover of *Golden*, yeah,” Taylor says.

“Okay, that’s not germane to the conversation,” Salazar protests, eager to regain control of the interrogation.

“May I have a drink?” Taylor asks.

“Well, here,” Hazel feeds a *Goodberry* to her.

“Thank you, stranger,” Taylor says, turning back to Salazar. “Now I’m thinking maybe I’ll answer questions from the rabbit instead.”

“Okay, fine,” Salazar leans forward, feeding her a drink of water. “Now, question. How did you become the leader of this... rogue section of the 51st Expedition?”

“Kaelen, the little prick, wanted to pursue his stupid family’s mission,” Taylor explains. “And we were like, ‘No, of course not, we’ve gotta focus on the whole reason we are here,’ and then he was like ‘No, we’re going to go to the stupid place to do some stupid thing,’ and I was like ‘nah.’”

“Do celebrities... curse so much?” Vilde says.

“Wow, I mean, yeah,” Salazar replies. “I didn’t know you were this uncouth. Can you speak properly... like a real celebrity?”

“You know what, maybe some alcohol would soothe my disposition,” Taylor replies.

Salazar shrugs. “Does anyone object to the goddess of music getting some alcohol?”

“Yes,” Vilde replies. “Why should we give you alcohol? You’re the one locked up, not us.”

“My throat’s a little dry,” Taylor replies.

“Did the water not soothe that?”

“No,” Taylor replies.

“Okay,” Vilde crosses the room, yanking her hair backwards and pouring water directly into her mouth. The bard chokes, spitting out water as she is water boarded.

“What the heck - “

“What about now?” Vilde asks.

“Okay, chill,” Raphael says. “I’ll give you a swig.” Producing *tej*, the sorcerer lets Taylor take a drink.

As the waterskin leaves her lips, the bard locks eyes with Salazar and casts *Suggestion*. “Put the mask on.”

Realizing that the drop of honey in the liquor gave Taylor the ability to cast the spell, Raphael snaps his fingers and *Counterspells* the magic.

“Ah, see,” Vilde rolls her eyes. “What did I tell you?”

Hazel walks up to slap the bard, making sure to break her concentration.

“What was that for?!” Salazar demands.

Taylor shrugs. “I need to talk to Gwynne.”

“Who is Gwynne to you?” Hazel asks.

“She’s a friend,” Taylor replies. “And she’ll help me get out of this cage.” The bard lunges forward, straining against her manacles.

“Listen,” Raphael tries. “We’re not against you all. We are on your side. We just want to understand your relationships with each other and Kaelen - “

“Why am I answering your questions?” Taylor seethes. “Let me free, and then we’ll talk.”

“We will, after you answer our questions - “

“I’ve seen you talk to two of my Expedition mates, and none of them are free.”

Vilde walks up, pulling her head back again wordlessly and continuing the waterboarding. As water slaps onto the face of the bard and floods her airways, Taylor begins to suffocate. Her vision goes blur as Vilde offers a brief reprieve.

“Well, I tried to be a good cop,” Salazar says. “Now you’ve riled up the bad cops.”

Taylor takes a minute to catch her breath. “I don’t know any of you. I don’t know who you are. I don’t know what

you want. Why must I tell you anything? You can kill me for all I care. We are already bound for death.”

“You won’t die if you tell us the truth,” Salazar says.

“What truth?!” Taylor demands. “We didn’t kill anyone!”

“Okay, correct me if I’m wrong,” Raphael says. “Your objective is to get everyone out, and then go and destroy the Devourer.” Raphael looks at Taylor, who nods.

“And that’s our team’s objective as well,” Salazar says.

“And how would I know that?” Taylor snarls.

“You can cast *Zone of Truth* to see if we’re lying - “ Salazar replies.

“I CAN’T CAST ANYTHING!” Taylor slams against the manacles again. “Why don’t you let me free, and you can see what spells I can cast?”

“Would you be open to join us?” Vilde asks.

“Or, at the very least, fuck up Kaelen?” Raphael offers.

“As much as I’d like to do that, how?” Taylor asks. “We’re on death row.”

“We know a guy,” Vilde asks. “If I can waterboard you, I can save you.”

Taylor shrugs. “We’ll see. Get us out of these chains, and then I’ll talk.”

“I don’t like this attitude, to be honest,” Vilde says as the Party leaves the jail cell.

“Aiya, it’s like that one,” Salazar says. “She’s a diva.”

“She’s a time bomb,” Vilde affirms. “It’s dangerous. We don’t know what she’d do.”

“At the very least, we know she’s not going to work with Kaelen,” Raphael points out.

“Keep the mask in the *Bag of Holding*,” Wang Lei warns Salazar. “Let’s go talk to Breakbones, then.”

“Wait a minute,” Vilde says. “Are we letting all of them out?”

“We can just let all of them out, right?” Raphael asks. Wang Lei shrugs in agreement.

“Including Portia?” Salazar asks.

“Portia’s the most innocent,” Vilde says exasperatedly. “Do we want all of them to join us?”

“I was thinking maybe we could put the mask on her,” Salazar mutters.

“And when are we going to release them?” Vilde asks. “We might need to prepare for a hot exit after the dinner, especially if Mummy tries to pull something.

And, to be honest, I don’t trust Taylor and Eren. We could probably keep Ariadne as a guide, but the other two might not listen to us.”

“Agreed,” Raphael says. “She’s pretty uncooperative. Either way, the mask is a problem. Given the fact that we all have our own secrets,” the sorcerer looks around at the Party. “Taylor might exploit these fault lines and start a mutiny of some kind. Ariadne is fine, but Taylor might be a threat.”

Salazar sits quietly, reconciling his impression of a kind Taylor with the antagonistic bard he has just met. He wonders if she was always duplicitous in nature, or if the stressors of her current predicament drove her to be combative. “I think I can convince her, though - “

“You can’t convince shit,” Wang Lei says, to Raphael’s agreement.

“Yeah, it’s more likely she convinces *you*,” Vilde says.

The wizard returns to the jail cell, unmuzzling Taylor to try anyway. The bard watches his approach, gently lifting her head for him to undo the muzzle.

“Goddess of music,” Salazar begins. “Whatever you experienced earlier - “

“Do you have any more *tej*?” Taylor interjects.

“Uh, no,” Salazar replies. “Anyway, I do apologise for everything you have experienced earlier. Please, know that this is all temporary. I am a huge fan of you and if you can join me on this life-changing Expedition to take out the Devourer it would mean a lot to me and my friends, who are also huge fans of you by the way. Who knows, by the end of all this we might be friends in Ophidia. What do you think?”

The bard shuts her eyes and raises her head slightly as he speaks, barely concealing her annoyance at the yammering wizard. “Do you have any more *tej*?”

“Can I take that as a yes?” Salazar asks.

The bard stays silent, prompting Salazar to remuzzle her and leave. As he rejoins the Party, he finds Wang Lei sharing with the group that a murder trial as high-profile as the death of a Castellan would likely take several months, even after the prisoners were shipped back. He also shares that it is likely an inquisitor or investigator has been appointed to gather evidence, and they are already likely on their way here to take statements.

“We just need to pin it all on Kaelen,” Raphael repeats.

“Yeah, but there’s a new problem, right?” Vilde points out. “I’m not sure if Breakbones will just let them free based on what we say.”

"Well, she should," Raphael says. "She's in on it with us. We'll just strike a deal with the prisoners, tell them that they'll only be set free if they agree to pin it all on Kaelen."

"And if the inquisitor asks where are the prisoners?" Vilde says.

"We'll just stall him," Raphael says.

With their plans decided, Wang Lei and Raphael heads off to find Breakbones as Hazel and Wukong return to their rooms to prepare for the dinner. Vilde and Salazar peels off, hoping to catch her father.

The sorcerer and paladin find Breakbones in her office. The half-orc sees their approach, and quickly locks the door behind both of them as they enter. "How was the conversation with the prisoners?"

"It was okay," Wang Lei says. "As you know, this bunch of people are all innocent. We are thinking of changing tactics and shifting the blame to the other group who has splintered off instead."

Breakbones checks her notes. "K-Kaelen, right?"

Wang Lei nods. "That's who we're after. He has a team of four including him. The four we have now, Taylor, Gwynne, Eren and Ariadne, they have the same objectives as us. We are thinking of letting them go, on the condition that they lie for us to pin it on Kaelen."

"We've checked too," Raphael says. "These bunch don't know anything about Sergeant Pearne."

CHARISMA (PERSUASION) CHECK

On a nat **20** check, Breakbones is convinced to let the Party free the captured half of the 51st Expedition.

"I - I have a lot of respect for your crew," Breakbones says slowly. "You guys are the only reason the Camp is still standing, much less the bustling beacon of hope it is in this wretched jungle. I would love to help you do this, but we can't just set them free. We can't just let them go. They are already sending someone to come down to take statements and start an investigation. Maybe if we stage a breakout or something, then, maybe, I don't know, I can tell them that there was a lapse and they broke free - "

"Well, we can stage a breakout," Wang Lei says. "In fact, we do have experience in that." The pair start discussing possible plans.

"Actually, it's best if you don't have this conversation in front of me," Breakbones warns. "I only have one rule. Nobody dies."

"As a matter of fact," Wang Lei nods. "Put Goldenguard on duty. I caught him selling drugs in the camp. Take

this as his penance."

A DEAL WITH A CHEATER

On the way, Vilde catches Salazar up on her conversation with her father. The rogue explains her suspicion that her father had brought the swords, and explains her desire to steal it from him.

"That's not very ethical," Salazar points out.

"You know what's also not very ethical?" Vilde says. "Cheating on Mummy."

INTELLIGENCE (INVESTIGATION) CHECK

On a DC **20** check, the pair finds Angwyn cooking in the kitchen.

Seeing his daughter approach, Angwyn dismisses the rest of the servants helping with the meal. As the trio are left alone, the elf wipes his hands clean on the apron and asks, "So, Vilde. Who's this?"

"One of my expedition mates," Vilde explains. "I believe you know him actually, we worked on some projects back in the day - "

"Your expedition?" Angwyn asks. "Isn't it technically your mother's expedition?"

"Okay, you know what," The rogue cuts to the chase. "I know what you did all those years ago, so maybe don't talk so much."

"What did I do?" Angwyn asks.

"Enjoying two women, that's what you did." Vilde spat.

CHARISMA (INTIMIDATION) CHECK

On a DC **20** check, Angwyn comes clean.

"Have you - " Angwyn catches himself momentarily. "Are you going to tell your mum?"

"Well, it depends," Vilde continues. "When we were talking back there, I saw a look that you had. I know you brought the items I asked for."

The elf smiles. "I love your mother - "

WISDOM (INSIGHT) CHECK

On a DC **15** check, Vilde sees true love in her father's eyes.

"If that's true, then why did you cheat on her?" Vilde demands.

"It's complicated," Angwyn explains. "She's a busy woman, and - "

"And what? You have needs?" Vilde asks.

Angwyn looks remorseful as he sits down on a stool. "I'm not here to defend myself," He says. "I know I did something bad, and I regret it every day."

"Well, now, what I need you to do, for me to keep your secret, is to give me the scimitars, and go convince Mummy that I should be the leader of the Expedition."

The elf leans back. "That's why I brought them here. I want you to take the scimitars, and get out of here as fast as possible. You know your mum, there's no convincing her. She's never going to let her only daughter risk her life in place of her own. That said," Angwyn leans forward. "I can help you. I can be here, when she realizes that you are gone, and hold her back. Or, maybe even lead her on a wild goose chase back to safety."

"Great," Vilde says. "We'll leave tomorrow night, so be prepared."

Angwyn raises his eyebrows. "You want to leave tomorrow instead?"

"There are things we have to do - "

"Then do them quickly," Angwyn says.

Suspicious, Vilde asks, "Is something going to happen at the dinner?"

"Nothing's going to happen at the dinner," Angwyn explains. "She just wants to get to know her new Expedition mates. But, *after* the dinner, what I heard was that she went to Breakbones and requested for several guards outside your room to make sure you don't pull any tricks. Two outside your door, two in the window outside. They have orders to escort you onto a boat bound for Port M'Kaze, and then a ship back to the mainland tomorrow morning."

"Go convince her that we'll delay it by a day, then."

"Have you ever seen me convince her to do anything?" Angwyn asks.

"I believe you can do it," Vilde says. "It's either that, or she learns the truth. Now, give me the scimitars."

Recalling the cooks, the trio head back into Angwyn's room. He produces two identical scimitars with red and blue draconic guards and winglike blades. "Our family's heirloom. Do not lose it. Do not break it."

"You don't have to tell me twice," Vilde replies. "I'm responsible."

"It might help you escape," Angwyn also produces an *Eversmoking Bottle*, passing it over to Vilde. "Listen... Vilde. I'm not doing this because I want you to die. Far from it. I'm doing it because I don't want my wife to die."



To head out there and face this... treacherous jungle alone."

Vilde keeps quiet, considering that her father may love her mother but than he loves her.

"Anyway," Angwyn continues. "Have you ever met your birth mother?"

"I might have chanced upon her, yeah," Vilde says.

"Where is she?"

"Does it matter?" Vilde asks.

"I'd like to visit her," Angwyn says.

"I don't think you should," Vilde continues. "I think you should focus on Mummy. And if I find out that you've visited her, I'll tell Mummy."

CHARISMA (INTIMIDATION) CHECK

Failing a DC 15 check, Angwyn is not intimidated.

"Don't speak to me like that, young lady," Angwyn says. "In any case, I'm headed back to the kitchen. Good luck."

As the elf gets up to leave, Vilde says, "Wait. Daddy, I don't know whether I can forgive you yet. But I appreciate that you stayed with Mummy all these years. I see that you love her."

"I've only ever loved one woman, Vilde. It is your mum," Angwyn says with a soft smile. "Or, rather, it is the Senator."

"You don't love me?" Vilde asks, incredulous. Storming out of the room in tears, the rogue leaves.